MCGILL RETAIL GEN AI HACKATHON · FALL 2026

Build on AWS: Your Get-Started Guide

The AWS services you can build with, and how to get started

1 · Start building on AWS (free)

The new AWS Free Tier — simpler and safer for experimenting on your own.

1. Sign in with **Google, GitHub, or Apple**. For most new users, no credit card to start.
2. Get **$100 in free credits** and build right away in your first project.
3. Optionally paste the setup prompt into a **coding agent** to wire everything up.
4. On a paid plan, set a **spend limit** (from $20/mo). Hit it and the project pauses, no surprise bills.

Start: aws.amazon.com/free · About: AWS blog

2 · The tools you saw

Tool	What it is	Link
Amazon Bedrock	Many top models (Nova, Claude, Llama, Mistral) via one API. Knowledge Bases + Guardrails.	https://aws.amazon.com/bedrock/
Bedrock AgentCore	Runtime, memory, gateway, identity, observability to run agents at scale. Any framework.	https://aws.amazon.com/bedrock/agentcore/
Strands Agents SDK	Open-source (Python/TypeScript). A working agent in a few lines. A fast on-ramp.	https://strandsagents.com/
Kiro	AWS agentic IDE. Spec-driven: prompt to spec to code. Free tier (50 credits); paid from $20/mo.	https://kiro.dev/

Jump straight to agents: AgentCore CLI quickstart

3 · Watch

[Channel] AWS Developers on YouTube — your keep-learning home — https://www.youtube.com/@awsdevelopers

[Strands] How AI agents really work (11:06) — Ch.1 of the free 'Building AI Agent Harnesses with Strands Agents' course — https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZpXWGjISMs8&list=PLDzwjhH-4yhU&index=1

[Kiro] Introducing Kiro, an agentic IDE (2:46) — https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lYuxyp8lp_U

[Kiro] Kiro in 60 seconds (1:14) — https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BIuakTF6NMs

[Kiro+AgentCore] AI-driven development lifecycle (blog how-to) — https://aws.amazon.com/blogs/machine-learning/ai-driven-development-lifecycle-using-amazon-bedrock-agentcore/

4 · Keep learning (free)

Resource	What you get	Link

AWS Student Rewards	Verified students: 12 months of Skill Builder Premium (900+ courses, hands-on labs), AWS credits, and a certification exam voucher. Via AWS Builder Center.	https://builder.aws.com/learn/students
AWS Skill Builder	1,000+ free resources; GenAI & agents learning plans; SimuLearn.	https://skillbuilder.aws/
GenAI learning path	Curated courses on generative AI + Amazon Bedrock (Knowledge Bases, Agents, Guardrails).	https://aws.amazon.com/training/learn-about/generative-ai/
AI Practitioner cert	Achievable first AWS certification for your resume.	https://aws.amazon.com/certification/certified-ai-practitioner/
Cloud Credits for Research	Student awards up to $5,000 in AWS credits (faculty sponsor applies).	https://aws.amazon.com/government-education/research-and-technical-computing/cloud-credit-for-research/

5 · At the finals (Oct 15-16)

Your AWS environment

- One AWS account per finalist team
- AWS services at no charge for the event
- Activated the morning of Oct 15

The account is wiped at the end of Oct 16. Nothing survives. Keep code on GitHub and data/notes on your laptops as you go.

Mentors & jury

- **5 AWS Solutions Architects** on site for the full two days
- Ask about architecture, service choice, cost, security, debugging
- We guide and unblock you — we do not code your solution
- **Senior AWS leaders on the jury** (Manon Yelle, Lisa Richardson): how well you use AWS is an important factor in your score

Build tip: aim for a real agent, not just a chatbot — show reasoning and action (L2 to L3). Lean into AWS services and be ready to show and explain how you used them.

Presented by Vincent Rioux · Senior Solutions Architect, AWS Canada · Questions welcome in English or French
AI transparency: Amazon Quick was used to accelerate research and preparation for this workshop.